How do global merchandise exports change over time?

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CPI **+3.7** % Chg. from Yr. Ago on Sep 2026

Civ. Unemploy. Rate **4.2** % on Sep 2026

10-Yr. Treas. Rate **4.95** % on 2026-11-03

Real GDP **+3.4** % Comp

Real GDP **+3.4** %, Comp. Annual Rate of Chg. on Q3 2026

IP **+0.7** % Chg. on Sep 2026

Payroll Employment **+29** Chg., Thous. of Persons on Sep 2026

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The takeaway

Global merchandise exports do not change smoothly over time. They ebb and flow and undergo large changes in relatively short spans.

The data

The FRED graph above uses recently added data from the Federal Reserve Bank of Dallas's Database of Global Economic Indicators to track the value of exported goods between April 1981 and August 2026.

The data show the year-over-year percent growth rate in exports from the US (black line), other advanced economies (red line), emerging markets (blue line), and the world excluding the US (gray line).

Three broad takeaways

- Ebbs and flows are global
  Merchandise exports rise and fall together worldwide. Exporters everywhere sell into the same global market, so when global demand drops or surges, it hits all of them at once. The US is no exception: Its exports followed the same path through the downturns of 2001, 2007-2009, and 2020.
- Trade swings more than GDP
  Export growth has generally ranged from about −30% to +45%, far wider than swings in gross domestic product (GDP). Consider the Great Recession of 2007-2009. When US households and firms postponed purchasing big-ticket items such as automobiles and machinery, inflation-adjusted GDP decreased by 4.3% and world trade shrank by as much as 34.6%, the largest drop recorded in this dataset. The flip side is that rebounds are sharp, too.
- The value of the dollar shapes the trade picture
  As described by the Dallas Fed research staff members Valerie Grossman, Adrienne Mack, and Enrique Martínez-García, the data here measure exports in US dollars, deflated by US consumer prices. When the dollar strengthens, other countries' exports are worth fewer dollars even if shipments don't change. That helps explain the 2015-16 global slump in merchandise exports, when the broad dollar index rose 11% in a year.

Where exports stand now

As of July 2026, when the latest worldwide data are available, global export growth is picking up. It remains to be seen whether it will average double-digit growth, as during the 1990s and 2000s, or return to meager single-digit growth, as during the 2010s.

How this graph was created: Search FRED for “Merchandise Exports to World from Advanced Economies (Excluding U.S.), Aggregated Using U.S. Trade Weights.” Click “Edit Graph” and select the “Add Line” tab to search for “Merchandise Exports to World from Emerging Markets, Aggregated Using U.S. Trade Weights.” Don’t forget to click “Add data series.” Repeat this last

step to search for and add the other two series: “Merchandise Exports to World from U.S., Aggregated Using U.S. Trade Weights” and “Merchandise Exports to World from World (Excluding U.S.), Aggregated Using U.S. Trade Weights.”

Suggested by Diego Mendez-Carbajo.



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